DisplayCAL-CG

Display calibration and characterization powered by ArgyllCMS

App version 3.10.0.dev82

English edition

DisplayCAL-CG User Guide

Monitor calibration and profiling, step by step — GDC edition

Document version 2.0 · based on DisplayCAL-CG 3.10.0.dev82-cg.4

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1. What is DisplayCAL-CG

DisplayCAL-CG is a GDC edition of the open-source DisplayCAL project (the community continuation of Florian Höch's original work), repackaged and fully translated by GDC. The application calibrates and profiles your monitor using the ArgyllCMS measurement engine — the result is a monitor with correct, consistent colors no matter which application you're working in (photo, video, graphics).

> **Calibration vs. profiling — what's the difference**
> Calibration brings the monitor to a known target state (white point, luminance, tone curve) through hardware/software adjustments (the video card's curves). Profiling then measures how the calibrated monitor responds and writes an ICC profile that the rest of the system uses for accurate color correction. They're always done one after the other, in this order.

This guide walks through each of the 5 main tabs (Display & instrument, Calibration, Profiling, 3D LUT, Verification), the advanced tools available from the menus, and how to install/update the application on Mac and Windows.

> **You need a measurement device**
> DisplayCAL-CG CANNOT calibrate a monitor without a physical colorimeter or spectrophotometer connected via USB (e.g. X-Rite i1Display Pro, ColorMunki Display, Datacolor Spyder). The app auto-detects the connected device on the "Display & instrument" tab.

2. Installation

macOS

1. Download the DisplayCAL-CG.pkg package from the download page (gordas.dev/DisplayCAL-CG).
2. Double-click the downloaded .pkg file.
3. In the installer window, click Continue on each step until you reach the License page.
4. Read the GPLv3 license summary shown, click Agree (without explicit acceptance, the install cannot proceed — this is a requirement of the native macOS installer, not an optional step).
5. Click Install — the app and all 9 satellite tools (Profile Info, Curve Viewer, etc.) are installed directly into Applications, nothing to drag manually.
6. Open DisplayCAL-CG from Launchpad/Applications.

> **The package is Apple-signed and notarized**
> macOS Gatekeeper will let the app launch directly, without the "cannot be opened because it is from an unidentified developer" warning.

Windows

1. Download the DisplayCAL-CG-Setup.exe installer from the download page.
2. Double-click the downloaded file.
3. If the Windows SmartScreen warning appears ("Windows protected your PC"), click More info, then Run anyway.
4. On the installer's license page, select I accept the agreement — the "Next" button stays disabled until you check this.
5. Follow the installer's steps (the default location is recommended) through to Install.
6. Open DisplayCAL-CG from the Start Menu or the Desktop shortcut.

> **Why the SmartScreen warning appears**
> The Windows installer isn't (yet) signed with a paid code-signing certificate — the warning is normal for unsigned software, not a sign that the file is unsafe. Only download it from the official page above.

3. Guided calibration (5 steps)

The first tab, Guided calibration, takes you from a connected instrument to a verified profile in five steps. All advanced options stay available in the other tabs.

1. Monitor and instrument — the application shows what it detected. Some instruments share one USB identity (for example the i1 DisplayPro and ColorMunki Display), so it cannot tell the exact model by itself: you confirm it, and every line says whether it was detected by the system or confirmed by you.
2. Your goal — pick the purpose (photo, video, general use…). Each goal maps to a ready-made preset.
3. Preparation — a short checklist for the things the software cannot do for you (see below). Nothing is ticked automatically.
4. Measurement — a summary of what will happen, the measurement plan, and the start button.
5. Install and verify — opens only after a valid profile exists. After installing, the application reads back the active profile and tells you whether it is really the one that was just created.

> **If something is missing**
> When ArgyllCMS, a display or an instrument is not found, the first step says so plainly and what to do. The Argyll engine is included in the installer (verified against a fixed SHA-256 hash); if a download is ever needed, a file that does not match the expected hash is refused.

4. Physical preparation

Before measuring, the checklist covers the monitor (stable, final settings), the room (no light falling on the screen), and the instrument (correct placement, cable, cap). Each item has a short why with its sources, and you tick them yourself.

> **No universal warm-up time**
> There is no single warm-up time valid for every monitor. The application does not invent one: it shows a figure only when the instrument maker publishes it (for example 30 minutes for Datacolor SpyderX), and presents it as that maker's recommendation.

For the instruments whose placement is documented by the maker (Calibrite ColorChecker Display, Pro, Plus and Datacolor SpyderX) a short animation shows the steps, with a text version of each step; play/pause and previous/next buttons control it, and it respects the system “reduce motion” setting. For other instruments the steps are generic and say so. The animation always stops before measurement starts; the measurement window itself shows only neutral patches.

5. Measurement plan and long sessions

Step 4 shows the plan before anything starts: the profile type, the number of patches and an estimated time.

- Profile type — a matrix profile (one shared curve or per-channel curves) is small and predictable; a LUT profile (XYZ or Lab) describes more of the screen's behaviour but needs more patches. On macOS the preset uses the single-curve matrix, inherited from the original project because of reported problems with other types on that system. More patches is not automatically better: it costs time and only helps where the profile type can use it.
- Calibration vs profiling — calibration adjusts the screen towards a target; profiling measures it and writes the ICC profile. The chart (the set of patches) belongs to profiling.
- Safe long run (blocks) — a large chart can be measured in blocks of 250, 500 or 1000 patches. A finished block is saved to disk; if the run is interrupted, only the block in progress is lost. Each block repeats the white reference, so the run needs one extra patch per block and re-initialises the instrument between blocks. Instruments that need their own calibration cycle measure in one run.
- Keep the computer awake — on by default, only for the duration of the run, released at the end. It cannot prevent: closing the lid, choosing Sleep, the power button, a flat battery, locking the screen or switching user. Keep the computer plugged in and the session unlocked.

At the end of a long run the application shows a local notification (nothing leaves the computer).

6. If a run stops unexpectedly

While measuring, the application keeps a record on disk (a journal updated continuously, saved atomically, in the application's data folder). It records facts, not guesses: when activity was last seen, progress, which stage, how the measurement engine ended, memory and free disk space, and whether the computer was suspended.

At the next start, if a session never recorded an end, a window lists what is known and offers:

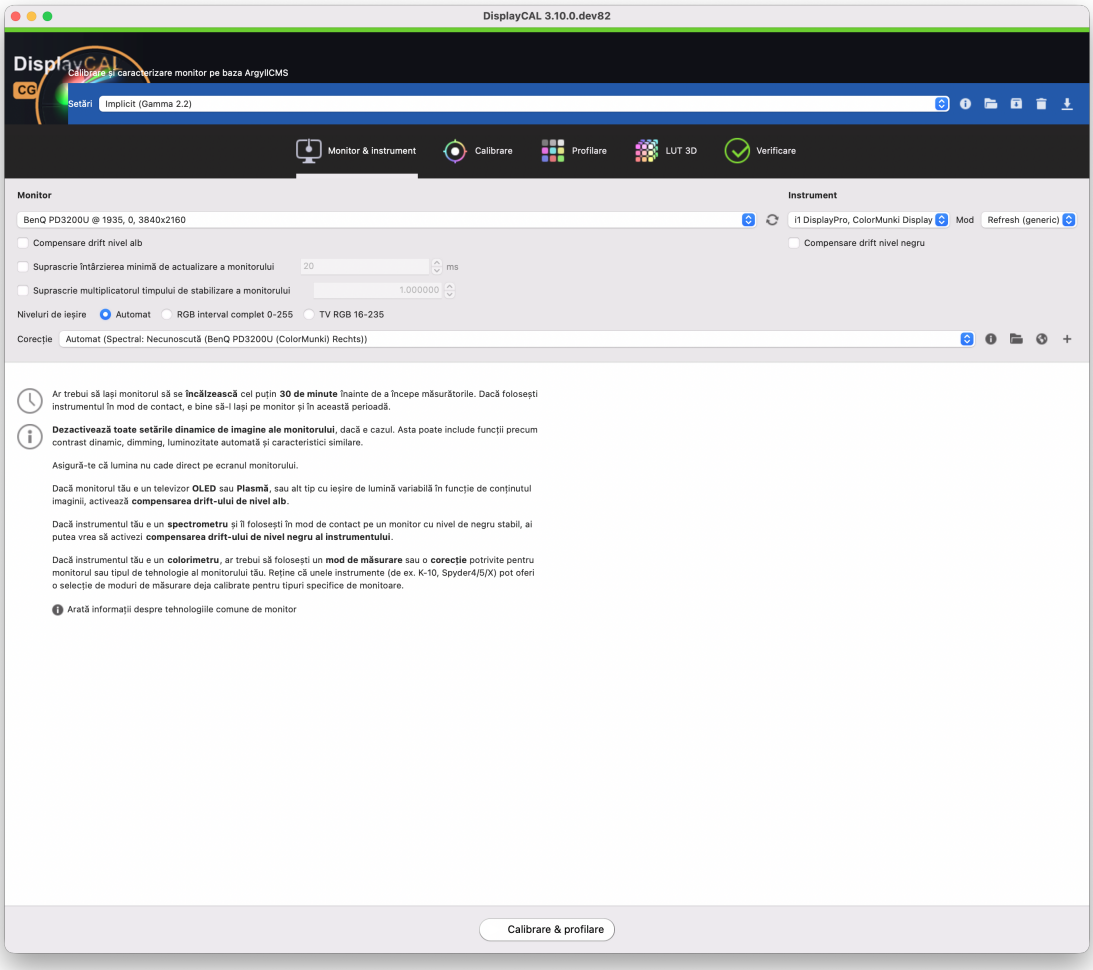
- Export everything recoverable to a folder of your choice.
- Show folder to inspect the files.

- Continue with the remaining blocks — offered only for runs measured in blocks, and only when the monitor, instrument, mode, correction, engine version and profile type are the same. Measurements taken under different conditions are never combined silently. The block that was in progress is measured again from its start.
- Dismiss or mark as seen.

> **What cannot be recovered**
> A run measured as a single block keeps its readings only inside the measurement engine until it ends; if it is interrupted, they are lost. That is why long runs should use blocks.

7. Display & instrument

The first tab — pick WHICH monitor you're calibrating and WITH WHICH instrument. The app needs to know both before you can move on to Calibration.



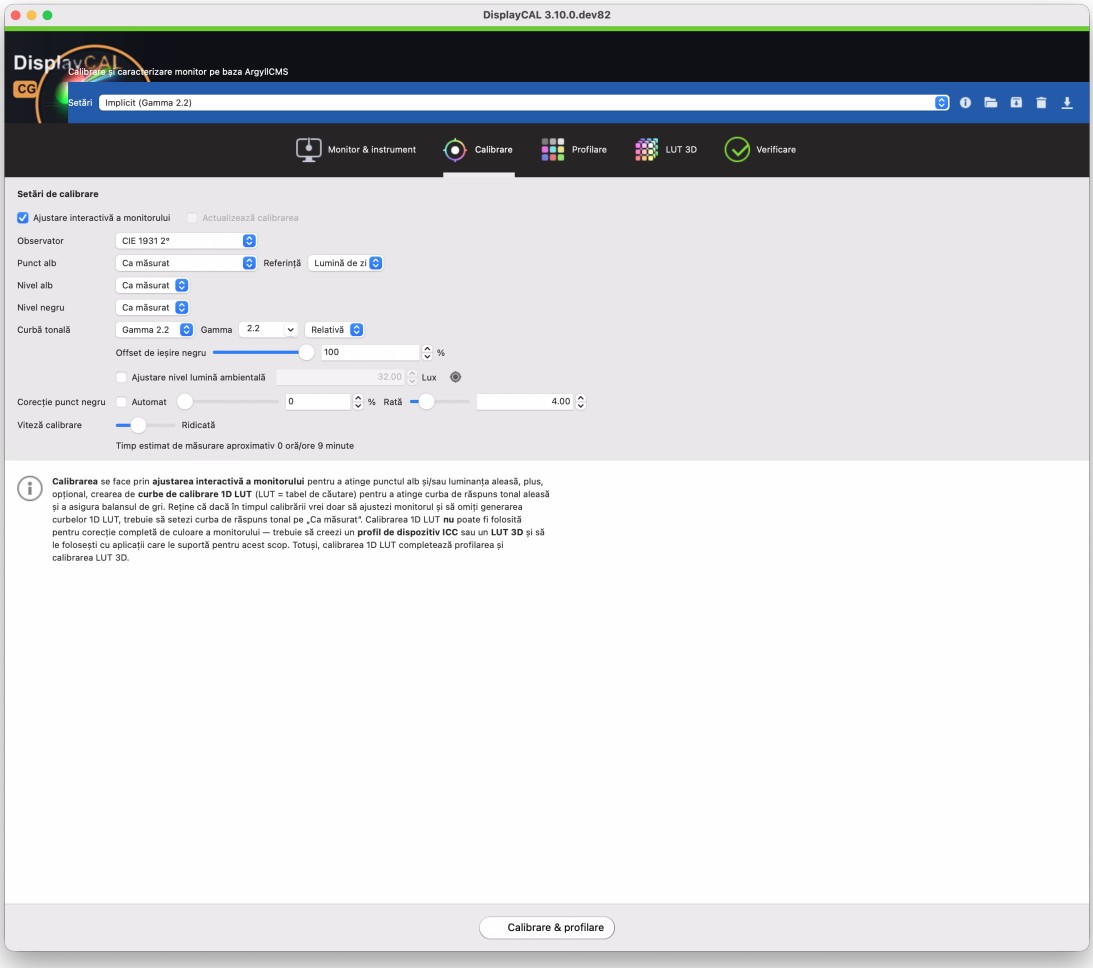
The Display & instrument tab, with an external monitor and an i1DisplayPro colorimeter already detected.

Field	What it does
Display	Pick the monitor to calibrate from the list if you have more than one connected. The round □ button next to it rescans connected displays.
Instrument	The colorimeter/spectrophotometer detected via USB. If it's empty, check the USB cable and that the instrument is recognized by the operating system.
Measurement mode	The instrument's measurement mode — "Refresh (generic)" suits most LCD/LED monitors. Some instruments (K-10, Spyder4/5/X) offer precalibrated modes for specific display types — pick the closest match if one exists.
White level drift compensation	Enable if the display is an OLED/Plasma TV or another type with variable light output depending on on-screen content.
Black level drift compensation	Enable if you're using a spectrometer in contact mode on a display with an unstable black level.
Output levels	"Auto" is correct in nearly all cases. "TV RGB 16-235" only applies if the display/video card deliberately limits the signal range, as with a TV used as a monitor.
Correction	The instrument+display specific color correction — DisplayCAL-CG picks it automatically ("Auto (Spectral: ...)") when it can; don't change it manually unless you know exactly what you're doing.

> **Before you measure**
> Let the display warm up for at least 30 minutes before calibrating — a cold monitor's colors drift as it stabilizes thermally. Turn off any dynamic picture settings (dynamic contrast, auto brightness) and avoid light falling directly on the screen during measurement.

8. Calibration

The second tab — choose WHAT target state you want for the display: what white point, what luminance, what tone curve.



Default calibration settings (Gamma 2.2, white point and levels "as measured").

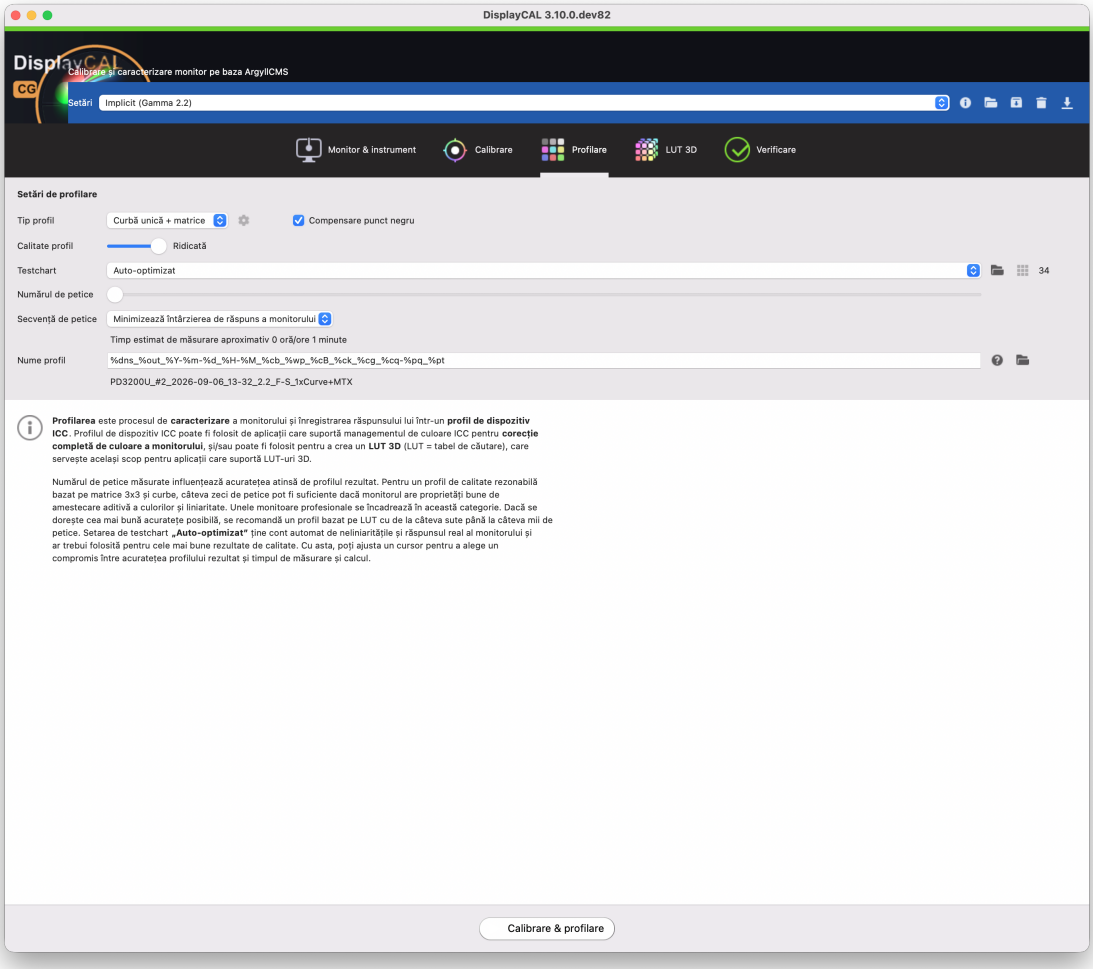
Field	What it does
Interactive display adjustment	When checked, the app guides you to manually adjust the monitor's physical controls (brightness, contrast, RGB) during calibration, to get as close as possible to the target before generating the software curves.
Observer	The CIE standard used to interpret color — "CIE 1931 2°" is the default, suitable for the vast majority of situations.
White point	"As measured" keeps the display's native white point. You can instead pick a fixed color temperature (e.g. 6500K/D65) if you need to hit an exact standard, with a reference ("Daylight"/"Black body").
White level / Black level	"As measured" keeps the display's native luminance. You can set a fixed value manually (e.g. 120 cd/m²) if you need to meet a luminance standard.
Tonal response curve	The shape the resulting tone response will have — "Gamma 2.2" is the default fit for photo/web; "Rec. 1886" or other curves matter mostly for video.

Field	What it does
Black output offset	0% = "pure" black; 100% = black follows the chosen curve exactly with no offset. In-between values compensate for displays with elevated black levels.
Black point correction	The rate/percentage used to correct near-black nonlinearities — "Auto" lets the app decide.
Calibration speed	A time/accuracy trade-off — "High" (default) is enough for most uses.

> **1D LUT calibration doesn't replace an ICC profile**
> The curves generated here only correct the display's overall tonality — for full color correction you also need a device ICC profile or a 3D LUT, created in the following tabs.

9. Profiling

The third tab — DisplayCAL-CG displays actual color patches on screen, measures them with the instrument, and builds the ICC profile that characterizes your now-calibrated display.



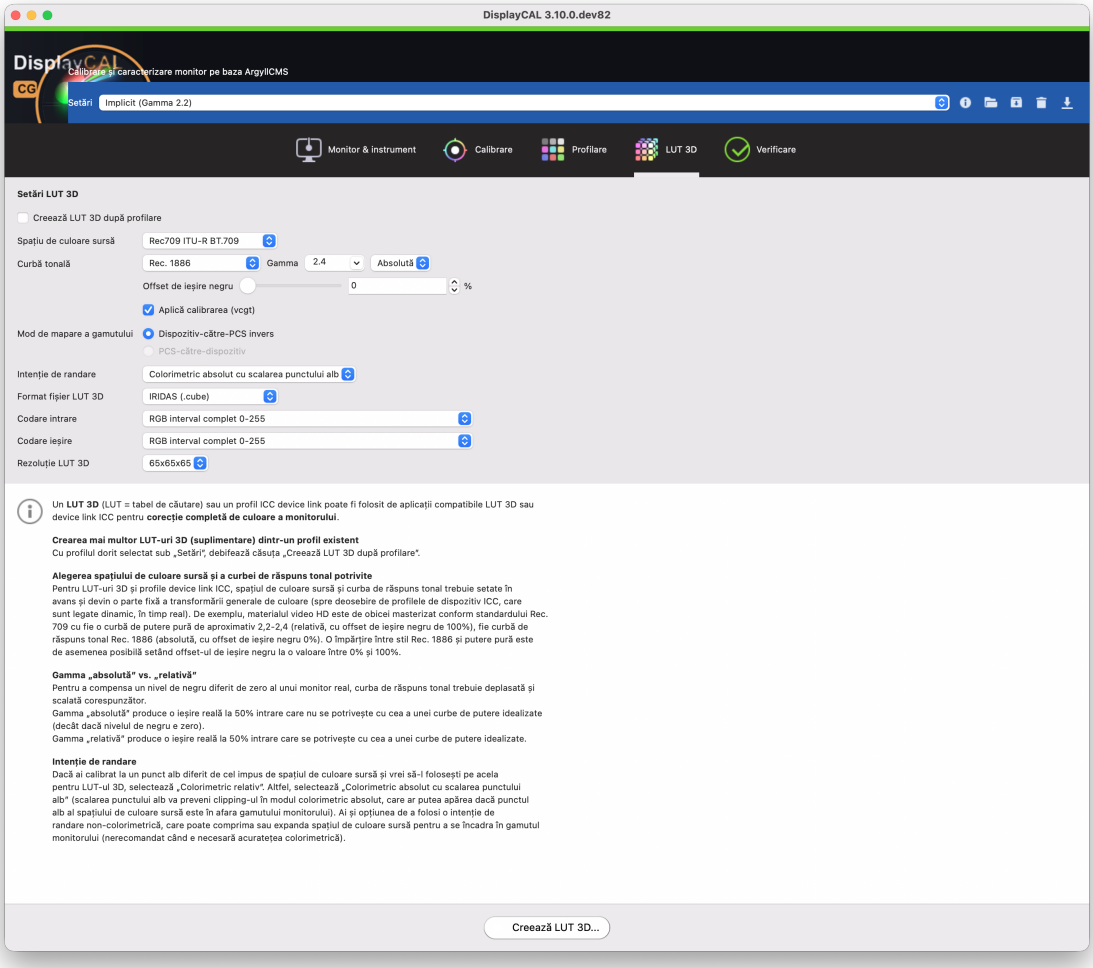
Profiling settings — "Single curve + matrix" profile type, auto-optimized testchart, 34 patches.

Field	What it does
Profile type	"Single curve + matrix" is fast and sufficient for many good displays; a LUT-based profile with hundreds to thousands of patches gives the best possible accuracy, but takes much longer.
Black point compensation	Recommended checked — improves accuracy in dark areas.
Profile quality	Low→High slider — affects how finely the profile is computed from the measured data, not the number of patches.
Testchart	"Auto-optimized" automatically picks patch distribution accounting for your display's actual nonlinearities — recommended for the best results.
Number of patches	The slider controls how many patches get measured — more patches = a more accurate profile, but a longer measurement.
Patch order	"Minimize display response delay" orders the patches to shorten total measurement time.
Profile name	The automatic naming template — you can freely edit the field below if you want a custom profile name.

How long it takes
The app shows an estimated time under the profiling settings (e.g. "about 1 minute" for 34 patches) — a LUT-based profile with thousands of patches can take anywhere from a few minutes to over an hour.

10. 3D LUT

An optional tab — generates a 3D LUT (a three-dimensional lookup table) from the profile already created, for applications that support color correction via 3D LUT instead of an ICC profile (common in video/color-grading workflows — DaVinci Resolve, media players).



3D LUT settings — Rec709 source, Rec.1886 curve, IRIDAS .cube format, 65×65×65 resolution.

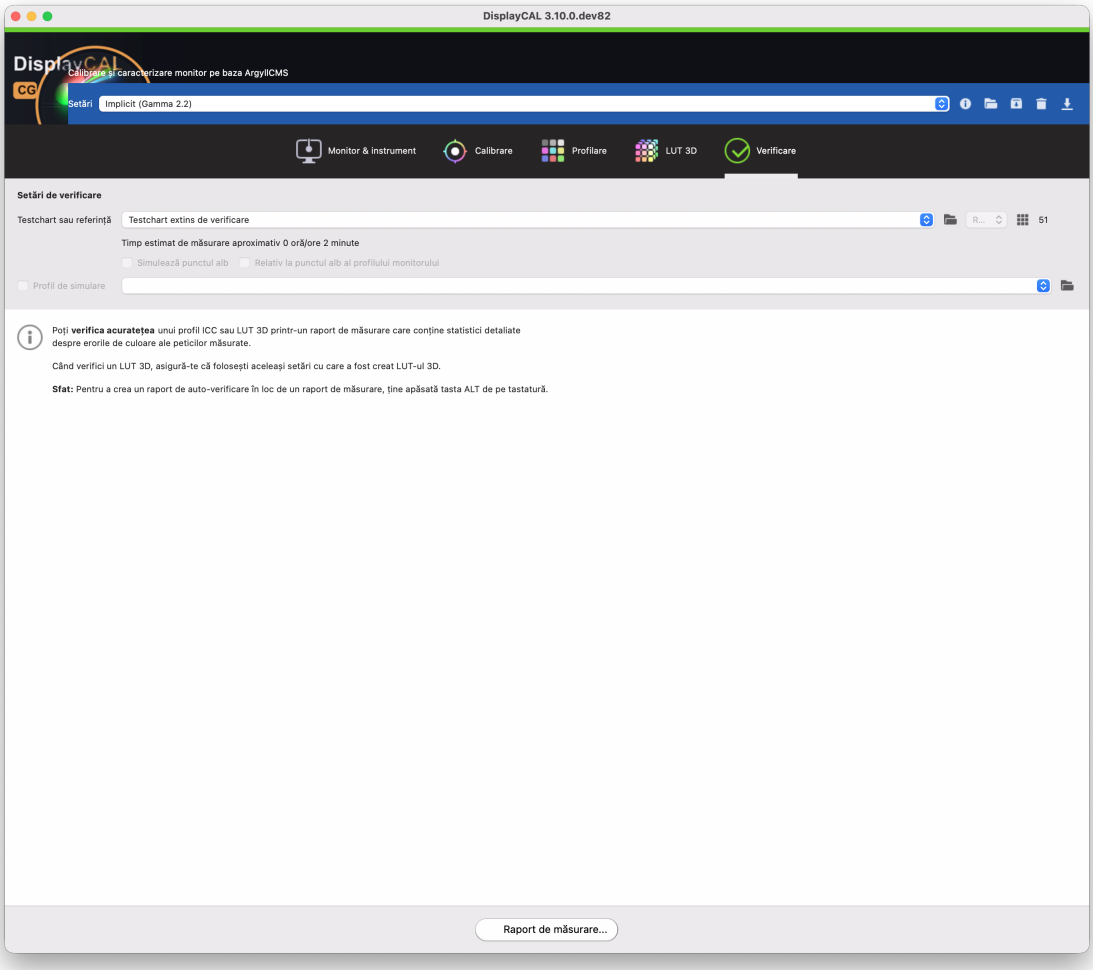
Field	What it does
Create 3D LUT after profiling	Check this if you want the LUT to be generated automatically right after profiling finishes, as one continuous step.
Source colorspace	The colorspace of the material you'll be playing back (e.g. "Rec709 ITU-R BT.709" for standard HD video).
Tone curve	Must match the source material's standard — HD video typically uses either a ~2.2-2.4 power curve or "Rec. 1886".
Gamut mapping mode	"Inverse device-to-PCS" is the standard choice for a display LUT (not a content-conversion LUT).
Rendering intent	"Absolute colorimetric with white point scaling" is recommended if you haven't explicitly calibrated to the source material's white point.
3D LUT file format	IRIDAS .cube is the most widely compatible (Resolve, most media players); other formats exist for specific software.

Field	What it does
3D LUT resolution	65×65×65 is a good accuracy/file-size trade-off — higher resolutions increase both precision and file size.

> **Use the SAME settings the LUT was created with**
> When later verifying an already-created 3D LUT (Verification tab), make sure you use exactly the same settings (source space, curve, rendering intent) — otherwise the verification result is meaningless.

11. Verification

The fifth tab — checks how accurate an already created ICC profile or 3D LUT is, via a measurement report with statistics on the color errors measured across a set of patches.



Verification settings — extended verification testchart, 51 patches, ~2 minutes estimated.

Field	What it does
Testchart or reference	The patch set used for verification — "Extended verification testchart" is a standard set, independent of the one used for profiling (otherwise the verification would be biased).
Simulate white point	Compares the result relative to a simulated white point, instead of the display's native one.
Relative to display profile white point	Similar to the above, but relative to the white point RECORDED in the current profile.
Simulation profile	Optional — checks how the display would behave if it simulated another profile/colorspace.

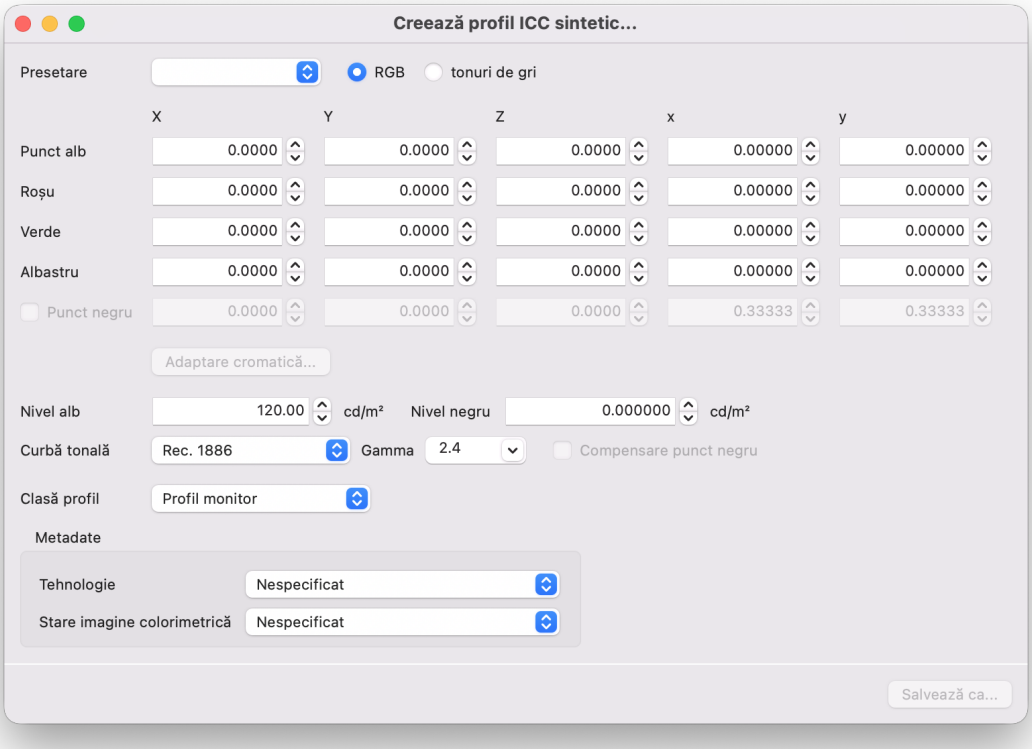
1. Pick the verification testchart (the default suits almost every case).
2. Click Measurement report... at the bottom of the window.
3. Follow the instrument on screen as the app displays and measures the test patches one by one.
4. At the end, a report opens with the average/maximum color errors measured (ΔE) — the lower the ΔE, the more accurate the profile.

> **Tip**
> Hold down the ALT key on your keyboard when clicking "Measurement report..." to create a self-check report instead of a regular measurement report.

12. Advanced tools

Besides the main workflow (the 5 tabs above), DisplayCAL-CG includes several standalone tools, useful for special cases — accessible from the main app's menu or as separate applications installed alongside it.

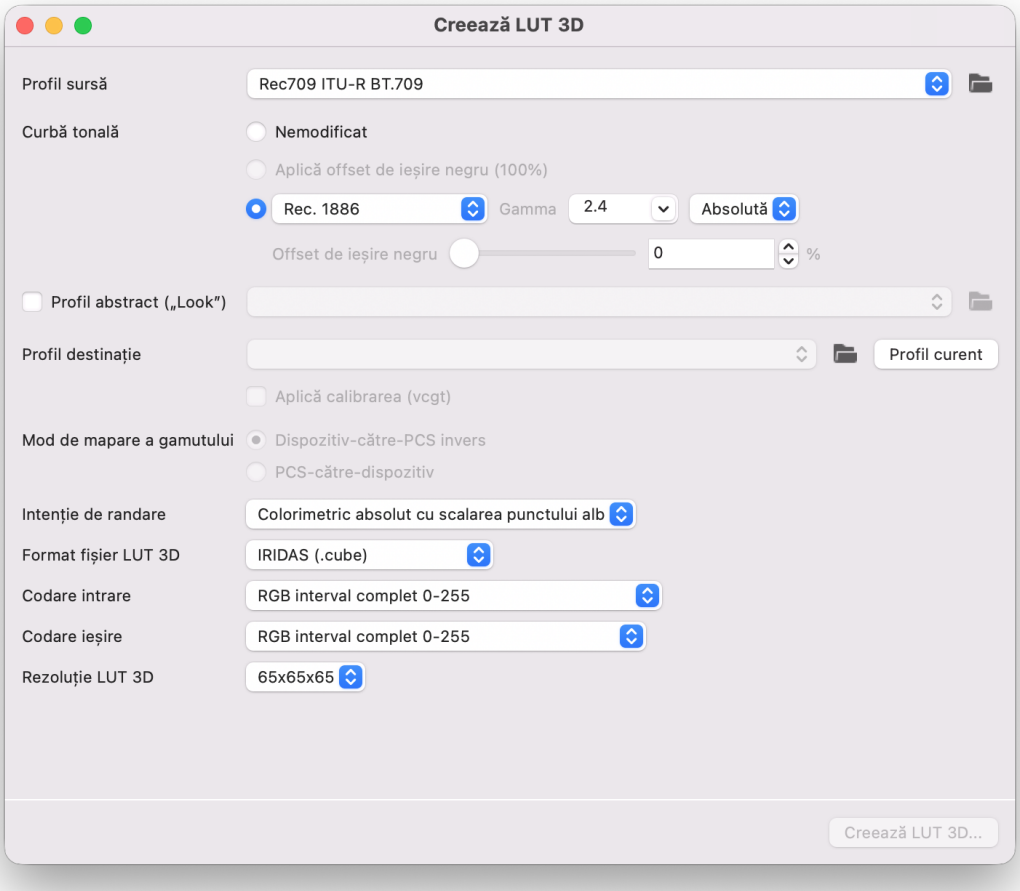
Create synthetic ICC profile



The synthetic ICC profile creation tool, built from manually described parameters (not from real measurements).

Builds an ICC profile from manually described parameters (white point, gamma, color primaries) — useful for generating a theoretical reference profile without measuring a real display (e.g. for simulation or testing).

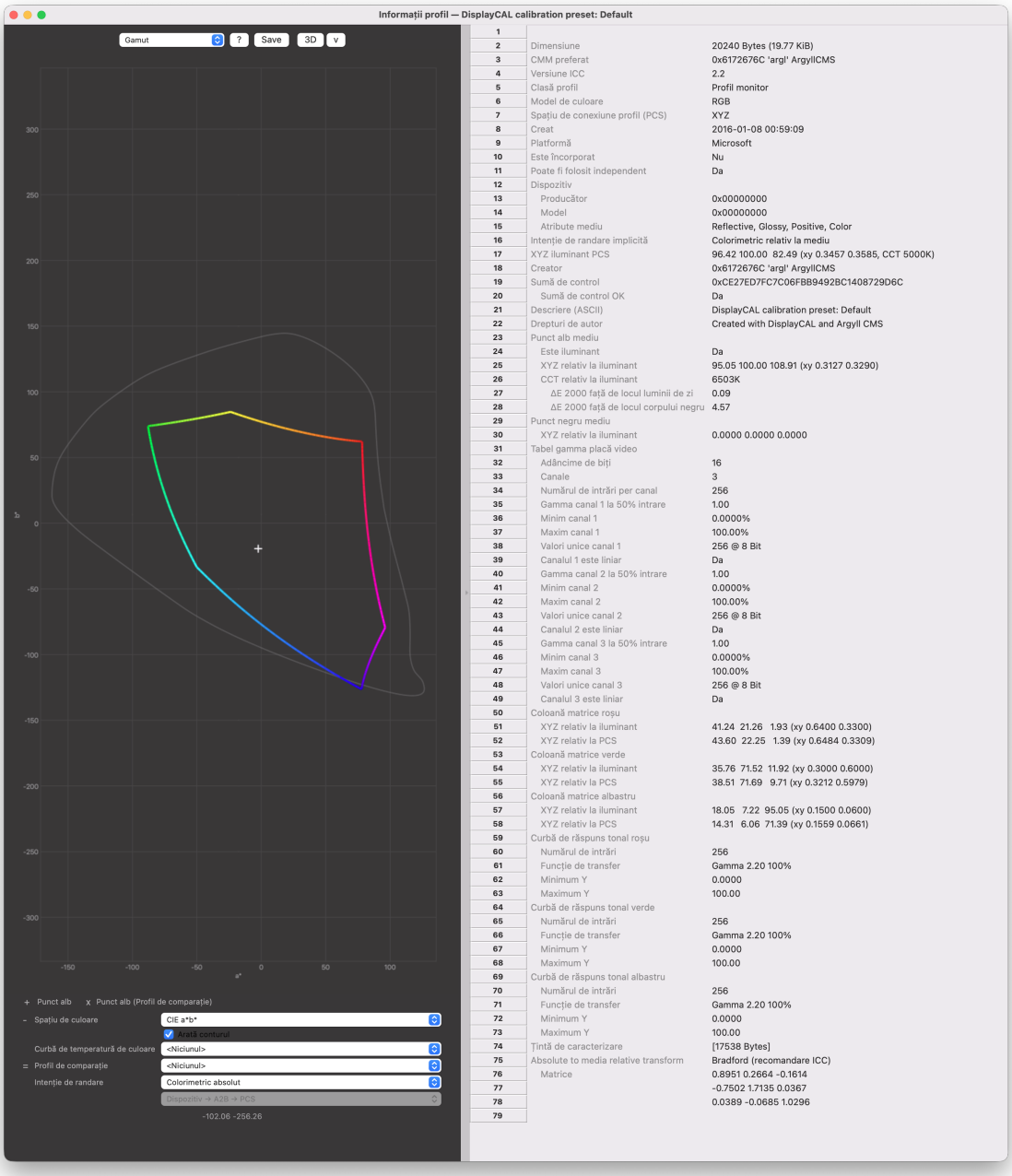
Create 3D LUT (standalone)



The standalone 3D LUT creation tool, for converting between colorspaces without going through a full display-calibration workflow.

The same 3D LUT generation logic as the "3D LUT" tab, but run independently of any display calibration workflow — useful for converting between two arbitrary profiles/colorspaces.

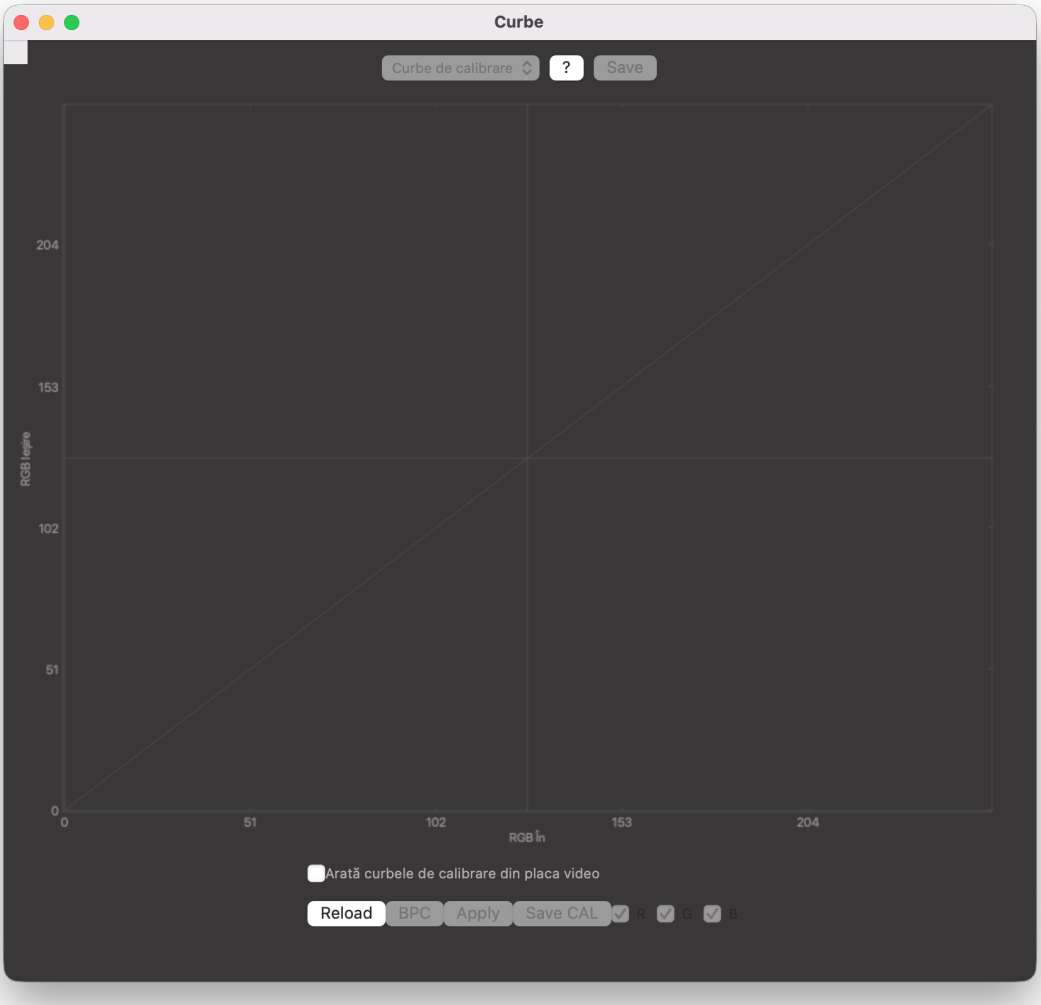
Profile Info



The Profile Info window — complete information about an ICC profile, plus a graphical representation of its gamut.

Opens any ICC profile (created by DisplayCAL-CG or from another source) and shows all the information it contains — white point, tone curve, color primaries — plus a 3D graphical representation of the covered color gamut.

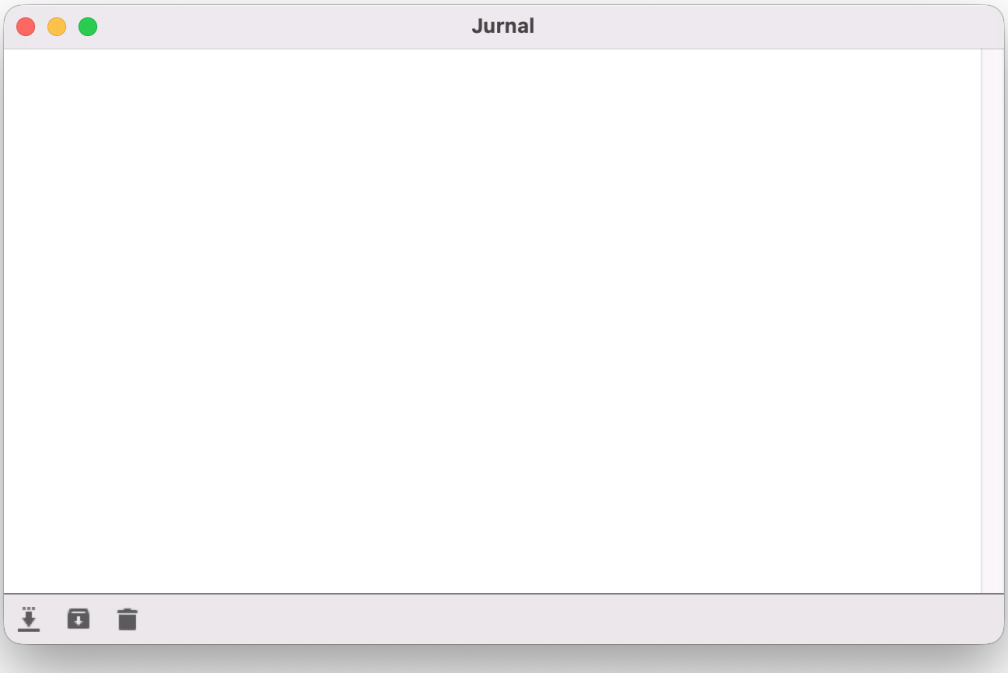
Curves



The Curves window — a visualization of the calibration curves (vcgt) currently loaded into the video card.

Graphically shows the calibration curves (VCGT — Video Card Gamma Table) currently loaded into the video card — useful for a quick visual check of what calibration is active right now.

Log



The Log window — the detailed technical log of the ArgyllCMS operations behind the application.

The detailed technical log of the ArgyllCMS commands run behind the scenes by the app — mainly useful for troubleshooting if something isn't working as expected and you want to understand exactly what happened.

13. GPLv3 license & optional support

> **100% free, forever**
> DisplayCAL-CG is free software, licensed under GPLv3 — fully functional from day one, no activation, no time-limited trial, no feature locked behind a payment. You can install, use and redistribute the application freely, subject to the included GPLv3 license terms (LICENSE.txt).

DisplayCAL-CG is built on the open-source work of DisplayCAL (Florian Höch) and its community continuators — full credits remain visible in the app (Help → About).

If the app has been useful to you, an optional support message appears occasionally in the application — it's purely informational, never a requirement to use any feature.

14. Support, feedback and credits

At the end of the flow, and in Help and About, two voluntary actions are offered: giving the project a star on GitHub (it only opens the repository page in your browser) and sending feedback (a small form that opens a pre-filled GitHub issue in your browser; you see what is included first, and the optional diagnostic has a preview and has personal paths removed). The application sends nothing itself and asks for no account. The invitation can be closed, or turned off for good.

Credits: DisplayCAL by Florian Höch, the displaycal-py3 continuation and its contributors, the ArgyllCMS engine by Graeme Gill, and this edition by Cristi Gordaș. Licence: GPLv3.

15. Updates

DisplayCAL-CG automatically checks at startup whether a newer version is available on the download page. You can also check manually from the Help menu.

1. If a new-version notification appears, click the link in it — it takes you straight to the download page with the latest version.
2. Download the new package (.pkg on Mac, .exe on Windows).
3. Install it over the current version, exactly as with the first install (see the "Installation" chapter) — your settings and already-created profiles remain untouched.
4. Restart the application after installing.